

That just meant we needed a DVI-to-HDMI cable for the TV, instead of a straight HDMI cable, and that we also needed a second Y-cable for the audio—no big deal, since we had them lying around. Straight-up HDMI does work under Linux, so if you have the extra cash, you could opt for a motherboard like the Asus M4A88TD-M/USB3.

Choosing the TV tuner card proved tougher. Most tuner card vendors shy away from declaring Linux support for individual models. Conversely, dozens of older cards work just fine under Linux, but are no longer available online (at least new in the box). With the help of a Hauppauge PR representative, we settled on the WinTV-HVR-1600—a TV tuner card that's widely available, relatively established, and still current.

Because this is a media center PC, initially we wanted to go with a component-style home theater case. We found plenty of attractive options from Ahanix, SilverStone, and even Thermaltake. We've used a number of these for past home theater PC builds. Antec used to have many, but now they're down to just a few.

But all of these cases cost over \$100—sometimes even over \$300—and feature

Windows-only enhancements like LCD displays and touch screens. That seemed like a waste of money. On the lower-end, nMEDIAPC has the nice-looking HTPC 5000B for just \$70 at Newegg. For this initial build, we didn't see much of a reason to spend more than the \$40 necessary to get the Cooler Master Elite 360. It's a bit of a pain to navigate, because the power supply is in the front and requires a little cable rerouting to get everything working. But it's small, stays cool, and looks good.

We were particularly pleased with our choice of input devices. The nMEDIAPC HTPCKB wireless keyboard and trackball is an awesome combination that makes controlling the PC from the living room couch a blast. We built our machine using a USB keyboard and mouse, but after it was finished, we switched to this setup (which uses a little USB receiver). It worked on the first try—even under Linux.

Mythbuntu and Initial Setup

We selected Mythbuntu 10.04 for our Linux distro. You can install Mythbuntu either as a package on top of Ubuntu 10.04, or as a clean install from an ISO CD image. We opted for the former, as many folks are already familiar with installing Ubuntu 10.04. In addition, installing Mythbuntu 10.04 from an ISO image leaves out some standard Ubuntu software packages, including OpenOffice.org. Even in that case, you can add the missing

WITH THAT, HERE'S OUR LOAD-OUT

COMPONENT	MODEL	PRICE
CPU	AMD Athlon II X3 440	\$77
Motherboard	Gigabyte GA-MA74GM-S2	\$50
Memory	OCZ Platinum 4GB DDR2/1066	\$71
TV Tuner Card	Hauppauge WinTV-HVR 1600	\$75
Hard Drive	Seagate Barracuda 7200.12 500GB	\$48
Optical Drive	Lite-On iHAS424 DVD burner	\$26
Case	Cooler Master Elite 360	\$40
Power Supply	OCZ StealthXStream OCZ600	\$60
Keyboard/Mouse	nMEDIAPC HTPCKB	\$60
Operating System	Mythbuntu 10.04	Free
TOTAL		\$507

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SEBI
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NSE
Barclays
Stumpp Scheule
GE Money
Religare Realty
ITC Maurya
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